

Dear McKinsey Recruiting Team,

I am applying for the Associate Intern position at McKinsey & Company. When a McKinsey recruiter visited the University of Minnesota and I had the chance to speak with them, something clicked: the way McKinsey thinks about problems, the emphasis on structured reasoning and communication, and the diversity of industries you work across all resonated deeply with how I already approach my own work. McKinsey has been at the top of my list since that conversation.

My interest in consulting is deliberate. After spending three years deep in transportation engineering research, I have developed strong analytical and leadership skills; but I have also realized that I do not want to limit myself to a single domain. Consulting, and McKinsey specifically, offers what I value most: the opportunity to apply rigorous problem-solving across industries, learn what different sectors look like from the inside, and then make a more informed choice about where to build my long-term career. I see this internship not as a detour from my expertise, but as the natural next step for someone who thrives on learning across boundaries.

What I would bring to your team is a combination of analytical depth and client-facing experience that is unusual for a Ph.D. candidate. For two years, I served as a key contributor on a project with the Minnesota Department of Transportation as the client — scoping problems, coordinating across engineers and agency stakeholders, managing deliverables, and presenting recommendations directly to decision-makers. That experience taught me how to balance technical rigor with what a client actually needs to hear, and how to align diverse perspectives toward a shared outcome. I authored two technical reports for MnDOT and led a field deployment that directly shaped the client's investment strategy — work that felt a lot like consulting before I knew to call it that.

Beyond research, I led a cross-functional team through the NSF I-Corps program, conducting 120+ customer discovery interviews, building a business case that secured \$50K in funding, and collaborating weekly with teams across finance, engineering, and technology. I also run a small vehicle resale business on the side — sourcing, pricing, negotiating, and closing sales with my own capital. These experiences have sharpened my instincts for understanding what people need and communicating solutions clearly.

Communication and leadership are not just items on my resume. They are what I genuinely enjoy. I have presented at INFORMS, TRB, and ITS Minnesota. I have taught statistics to +100 students, translating abstract concepts into accessible narratives. In every group project and collaboration, I am the person who organizes the team, respects every perspective in the room, and keeps things moving without creating friction. I took a course called Storytelling for Engineers specifically because I believe the best analysis means nothing if you cannot bring people along with you, and that belief is exactly why McKinsey appeals to me.

I would be excited to bring my analytical skills, client experience, and collaborative energy to a McKinsey team this summer. Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Maziar Zamanpour

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